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Peter Vacher

British jazz writer Peter Vacher was born on August 5, 1937. He played trombone as a youth, later directing his passion for jazz into the realm of writing. He has contributed to numerous jazz publications, including The Grove Encyclopedia of Jazz *and* Jazz Journal International. *He co-authored* Telling It Like It Is, *with his longtime friend clarinetist Joe Darensbourg.*

Peter was interviewed in Clearwater Beach, Florida on March 18, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are in Clearwater Beach. My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive and I'm really looking forward to talking to writer Peter Vacher.

PV: Thank you.

MR: And it's going to be interesting to get a look at the lives of jazz musicians from someone who writes extensively about them, for what forty years now?

PV: Yes it is actually.

MR: I want to tell you about Keith Ingham, who you are aware of, of course. I asked him about American musicians going to England and embracing English music, like he came over here, and he said, "Well we don't have anything as good as American jazz." What's your reaction to that statement?

PV: I think there's a whole built-in thing which seems to imply that because America is the home of the music that Americans must be its best practitioners. And I grew up with that. But I think a little bit of perspective starts to say that today jazz is an international music. It's a music of all nations. And I think I'd be prepared to say that we have some very fine players. Whether they have something that is so special that others this side of the pond might learn from it well I'll leave others to say. But we have produced some fine players if you think of someone like Joe Temperley, presently with the Lincoln Center Jazz Orchestra. I don't think we need to make any apologies for his playing capability. So maybe Keith was being a little bit — how can I put it — biased if you like. That's not to say that I wouldn't agree that of course the major innovators, the most considerable contributors, with the possible exception of Django Reinhardt, have been from this side of the pond.

MR: Yeah, and I'm not sure he was just talking about the musicians either. But he thought that jazz in itself was, I guess, better for him than any kind of music that he would have found in England.

PV: I think Keith fell in love with the music, didn't he?

MR: He sure did.

PV: And that's what he wanted to do. And he found I think the London scene, to a degree, restricting. And like a number of other English players, George Shearing of course, Derek Smith would be others, Marian McPartland you mentioned, he saw the bigger opportunity this side of the Atlantic, New York in particular being the focal point as he saw it, I'm sure that was justified. And I know because I spoke to him in the last year that he feels that it was a wholly good move. And who's to say he was wrong? As he sees it that must have been right for him.

MR: How did you fall in love with the music?

PV: Oh I can tell you quite specifically. I wrote a series not long ago called "The First Time," where I asked people about the kind of Damascene moment. And it was quite interesting, you know the different reactions. I know precisely when mine was. I was fifteen years of age. I was in France staying with some cousins, and I went down to a students' café, and on the juke box they were playing music I'd not heard before. And specifically I heard Sidney Bechet's version of "The Onions," "Les Onignons." Not a record I'd much want to hear now, but by gosh it bowled me over. And that was the moment. It was as specific as that. When I got back to London I found the record, bought the record, and of course that started to open up all sorts of possibilities.

MR: When were you born?

PV: '37. 1937.

MR: Did the American servicemen coming to England during the war have any impression on you, what they brought with them?

PV: No.

MR: Of course you were only — not too old.

PV: The only thing I can remember is that the favorite thing to do, if you saw American servicemen, was to go up to them and say, "Got any gum, chum?" And as kids, that's what we did. That was about it. I can remember seeing American servicemen around but no awareness that they might have brought music or anything like that at all.

MR: What was the music in your household like?

PV: I think my father's taste ran as far as Mantovani.

MR: Forty — okay.

PV: Yeah. Not too advanced, was it?

MR: Well it was in my house too.

PV: Yeah. They had their special musical interests at home. They just liked what they heard on the radio. Doris Day, Mantovani, Vera Lynn, you know, the kind of popular music — the popular music prior to the days of The Beatles and rock & roll if you like.

MR: But they didn't embrace any of the swing music that came over.

PV: No. And when I got involved they thought it was a very strange thing altogether.

MR: Did you lean towards being a writer even before the music—

PV: I was always good at English, I was always capable when it came to writing, but I hadn't thought in terms of writing. No, what led me to writing was falling for the music and wanting to play the music. And very early on, about sixteen or seventeen, after this hearing Sidney Bechet on record, I started to think well I must try and do something. And what I remember in particular was "The Glenn Miller Story," when that came out. My pal and I saw it three times in one week. And I remember to this day walking up, where we lived, and us saying together we're going to have a band. We hadn't actually worked out what we were going to play, we hadn't worked out whether we could ever manage to do it, but we were going to have a band. And we kind of tossed a coin and I got the trombone and he went and got the trumpet and that's how it started. And we wanted to play. And we found other like minds at school, because we were all at the same school, and we formed a jazz band. And we had a lot of fun. And well, it was probably just an amateur thing but it was great fun and we had a little fun doing it you know.

MR: So you hadn't played the trombone before that?

PV: Nope. Nope.

MR: That's interesting.

PV: I had done no musical study, we didn't have a piano at home, I just found this desire to play the trombone out of this, well, inspirational moment. And I thought well all you've got to do, you pick it up and you blow into it. I'd already played the bugle in the, we had a Cadet Corps, a marching band at school, and I'd played the bugle in that, I'd played the fife, which is a small flute, and I also played the tenor drum. So I was already kind of involved with that kind of musical activity, quite limited, before I'd got some lip, so I'd played the bugle for a number of years, so I knew how to get a note out of the trombone, that was all right. But the difficult bit is about which notes, you know, I had to try to deal with later.

MR: I saw that movie, I can't begin to tell you how many times. In fact I never forgave you guys for that English Channel thing that he went down in.

PV: Yes. That's right. It wasn't our fault, honestly. Although they still think there's the possibility of finding him one day. They're still looking down there.

MR: Well did it occur to you at that point that maybe there's a career for me at some point here?

PV: No. We were just doing this because, it was the time of the English traditional jazz revival, the trad boom, right? That's the period we're talking about. Middle '50s, before I went into the Army, and it was just about the time that people like Chris Barber, Ken Collier, Acker Bilk, all those guys were kind of getting going, and we were just kind of

bowled over by this. Strictly traditional jazz. I wanted to play traditional jazz. By that time I knew who Kid Ory was and I was aware that that was the kind of jazz music I wanted to have a go at. And we all felt the same, you know, quite purist and just wanted to have a go at it.

MR: Were those records fairly easy to get?

PV: Oh yeah, yeah. Not in great quantity, I mean it was the days of 78s. I mean you kind of went down to the record shop to see what had come in, what had been released. And the first record I bought, I can still remember, was a 78 of Jelly Roll Morton "Smokehouse Blues," the second one was Kid Ory's "Oh Didn't He Ramble," and that's the band sound that we thought ahh, that's what we want to do. We want to play like Kid Ory's Creole Jazz Band. I'm not quite sure we made that, but that's what we wanted to do.

MR: Did you ever make any money doing it?

PV: We played youth clubs and school things. So what you might get was beer and sandwiches. I don't think anyone ever paid us actual money, but they kind of said come along and play and you can have as much beer to drink or you can have as much food as you want, or something like that. And the irony of it was that we'd got just about our real professional breakthrough, if that was going to be it, when we were named as the interval band at a dance in the center of London, where there was a quite well known jazz band as the principal band. And the tickets were printed, our band was called the Apex Stompers. And there was Dave Carey's Jazz Band, which was quite well known, and the Apex Stompers. And that was week I was called up to go to military service. So that was our kind of prime moment, and I wasn't there. So there you are you see. It was a tough break. I had to go to the Army. I couldn't sort of say to the Army look I've got this important opportunity.

MR: You said you were the interval band, the relief band, is that what they called you?

PV: Yeah. But our name was on the poster, our name was on the tickets, you know, we were going to really do it. So there you are.

MR: Oh man. Couldn't get a deferment?

PV: Nope. They weren't prepared to listen to any of that.

MR: What did you end up doing in the military?

PV: I went and served in the Cavalry, that's the tank corps in England and in Germany, but I did basically clerical jobs, in what we called the Order Room, which is the headquarters.

MR: Okay so you get out of the service and you were what, in your late 20s?

PV: No, I was about 21 I suppose. We just did two years national service you see. I bought my trombone with me everywhere. I never found any other people that wanted to play, but I played, all on my own. A bit pathetic. Re-formed the band when we came out. It wasn't quite the same again. And by that time, with two years gone, we'd lost ground.

You know we hadn't improved like others of our equivalent had improved. And we realized that we were kind of playing catch-up. And I knew it wasn't going to really happen. Jazz is a demanding music art form as we all know. And it was a bit late in the day.

MR: Do you think that even that limited amount of playing you did in the genre helped you write?

PV: What it made me want to do is to communicate. I mean the reason I write then and now is out of a desire to communicate about my enthusiasm for this music. It's an evangelistic process as far as I'm concerned. I'm trying to stop people and trying to say hey, listen to this, experience it. And I think once I knew that we weren't going to get very far by playing, a sort of odd sequence took place. I can just remember thinking I really ought to be writing about this, because it's important and I want to make sure that other people get some sense of why it's important. Now that's all very pretentious but that is what was in my mind. So I started writing very early on in my twenties, once the bands started to kind of fall by the wayside, I started to have a go at trying to write reviews and just, well, see if I could get something into print.

MR: Yeah. A lot of knocking on doors and trying to make connections?

PV: Well a little bit of that. I was very much helped by a marvelous man called Max Jones who was the premiere jazz critic of the "Melody Maker." I got to know him early and we stayed firm friends right through to the end of his life. And he let me put, he started to publish little bits by me in the "Melody Maker" in the late 50s, and that was helpful. By then I'd started corresponding with one or two musicians and things like that. And you could kind of pass on a few newsy tidbits, and they would go into Max's column. So I got the taste for it that sort of way.

MR: I don't know if this is a generalization but the British writers seem to take great pride in details and making things absolutely correct, and I think of Chris Sheridan and the book on Count Basie that is unbelievable.

PV: Sure. Do you know about the one he's doing on Monk?

MR: No.

PV: It's due out anytime now. It's 545 pages. And he's done one on Cannonball Adderley as well.

MR: Ooh.

PV: Yes that will excite you.

MR: Okay. Is that out?

PV: I think it's coming out anytime if not already. It's probably emerged by now. Yeah I know Chris, he's assiduous.

MR: He's what?

PV: He's assiduous

MR: Assiduous.

PV: We were very fortunate. There was a number of writers who I think in a way, this is a difficult claim, seemed to take the music more seriously than their American counterparts. You know you have people like Panassié in France and Charles Delaunay. And in London you had Sinclair Traill who founded *Jazz Journal*, you had Max Jones, you had Charles Fox, you had Albert McCarthy. These are major people in terms of documenting the music. Albert McCarthy along with Charles Delaunay were the first discographers. There were good magazines to write for. So quite early on I was getting into magazines which were magazines of quality. And it was principally because of these key people, particularly, as I say, Max of the *Melody Maker*, and then Albert McCarthy with *Jazz Monthly*, which was a fine magazine, a bit on the lines of the *Jazz Review*, Nat Hentoff's thing.

MR: Is there an exotic factor to something, an art form that comes from another country?

PV: I think all of us were kind of caught up in the racial element of it. You know a lot of the writers and a lot of the opinion formers were leftward leaning, right socialist people, and what they were empathizing with was of course the situation for black Americans, a tremendous interest in the blues, a tremendous interest in the formative experiences of black musicians, and of a sense of trying to do something to arrest or correct injustice. That was a powerful strand in the kind of reading I did and in the kind of opinion that was being promoted and published. So a tremendous interest therefore in that black manifestation. I mean when I was starting out, a jazz writer would be as keen to cover jazz in the conventional sense of improvised small group or big band music as he would blues or Gospel. That doesn't apply today. But Max Jones would review and would enthuse about everyone from Marion Williams and the Stars of Faith, right through to Duke Ellington or Charlie Parker. They were all part of a piece as far as we were concerned. They were all aspects of the black experience, the black American experience. And in a sense they fit together as we saw it.

MR: Did they have an interest in people like Frankie Trumbauer, Bix Beiderbecke?

PV: Oh yes. Oh yes. Because the music of the white musicians that you're mentioning there was actually released far more widely in Europe than was that of the black Americans perhaps. Those records were widely known. There is a whole sort of strand of people who are still very much devoted to that era of music or that particular genre of the music, oh yes. I wasn't drawn to those. I was drawn to the black players. I was drawn, Bechet for sure, Kid Ory, and then fell heavenly for Jelly Roll, the Hot Fives, the Hot Sevens, you know, and worked my way through those great and triumphant series of recordings. You know they were like manna from heaven.

MR: Put it in words for me if you can, what made them so distinguishable?

PV: The energy, which is still a powerful factor to me; the rhythmic drive; and just that sense that something was kind of bursting out of the grooves that was quite unlike anything else. To me then, Beiderbecke and Trumbauer seemed effete. All right? A little restrained. I like that sense of, you know, all out emotion. I think it was the emotion in other words. And I suppose by then I'd started to read a lot, you know I'd read Louis' autobiography by then. I'd read Bechet's autobiography. I'd read, Rudi Blesh's *Shining Trumpets*. There was a whole literature that was kind of inspiring and informing at the same time. And I think the focus then, and probably has continued to be, it was on the great black innovators. That sense that the momentum of the music came from these key people, from Jelly Roll, from Louis, from King Oliver if you like. They were the play makers. So I think that's what hit me hardest.

MR: Yeah. You got to a point where you actually could make a living as a writer?

PV: Naah. No. The writing has always been a parallel thing. I mean I got married when I was 24, we started to have our family. There's very few people in England, I can think of a couple of writers, in a sense, who said I'm going to be a full time and professional jazz writer. They were a rare breed. Max was on the *Melody Maker*. Okay? That was a full time job. He was very much the exception. Most of us were, I supposed, amateurs in the strict sense of the word, wanting to do things to document the music, interviewing musicians. I began to think every black person that walked up and down Oxford Street must be potentially a jazz musician you know. So if players came to town, people like me would swoop on them and try and get them to give us their stories. Because we wanted to document the music. Document the stories. I think probably by then one of the books that had interested me curiously was *Hear Me Talking to Ya*, you know the wonderful oral history. You know you thought God I want to do that. I want to get these stories before they all disappear you know.

MR: Were you perhaps one of the first people to hit on some of these guys for stories do you think? Because nowadays a lot of them have been telling their stories a lot.

PV: Well I can certainly recall, I mean I brought the book I wrote about Joe Darensbourg. That started, and that may be worth talking about for a minute or two, I saw his address in Leonard Feather's own *Encyclopedia of Jazz*. So I wrote to him. You know, "Dear Joe, I'm an admirer of your music." And we struck up a correspondence. He came to London in about 1962, just after I got married, with Louis Armstrong's All-Stars. I interviewed him, that was the first time a full account of his career had ever appeared. That was in "Jazz Monthly." Ultimately that led to this. So I was, with some others, there was a wonderful writer called Valerie Wilmer who is still very, very active. A number of us I think were starting out with the idea of interviewing as many visiting American

musicians as we could get to. Not necessarily the big stars, but sometimes the piano player and the bass player, rather than the top soloist perhaps. Because you're right, obviously some of those have been interviewed extensively already. And I think that was quite a useful thing to do, enough of them was talking clearly for the first time in that sense. You know it was the first they'd been prompted to give their stories.

MR: Was there any problems with American black musicians with you gaining their trust?

PV: Illinois Jacquet said he'd like ten thousand dollars if that's what you mean. If I was to interview him.

MR: Was he negotiable?

PV: I later interviewed him without having to pay any dollars, so I think it was all right.

MR: Well you got farther than I did with him.

PV: Did you? Or did I rather?

MR: I never got past his wife I think.

PV: Oh yes. The lady bassoon player. Carol. The current Mrs. Jacquet?

MR: I can't even remember. It's been a couple of years.

PV: Yes, that would be Carol. She forswore him from alcohol and other matters. She has been his savior he tells me.

MR: All right.

PV: Yeah. Fair enough. No I don't think so. I think most of the guys that came over, I mean I've interviewed quite a number of older guys from New Orleans or some of the younger, sharper cats. I never sensed — because hopefully what one is conveying is enthusiasm for the music. I'm trying to say look, I've so much enjoyed hearing what you do, and participating in what you do, that I want to find out more and tell people something about you. And I don't think that's an unwelcome message for most people. Sometimes you got the sense that — I mean when I interviewed Art Blakey, because I was a feature writer for the "Melody Maker" by then, when you interviewed someone like Art Blakey, as I said to you the other night, what you got was the standard interview. "Let me tell you what I want to tell you." And sometimes that's difficult to break down. But it wasn't a racial or a sort of cultural thing, it was just breaking through what was already a kind of set pattern or routine.

MR: Do you have to balance what you want to write about and what an editor might want you to write about?

PV: I do now. Much more now. We're very fortunate. In the 60s when I was getting into my stride on all this, *Jazz Monthly*, *Jazz Journal* was also at its peak then. I was writing for *Coda* in Canada. They almost, there was an openness. I don't remember any editor saying, "Oh I don't think we want to publish his story." That is not the position now. I mean for instance I interviewed John Hicks, a terrific piano player about eighteen months

ago — a couple of years ago. I can not place the full story, an as-told-to oral history type piece on John Hicks. Whereas previously I would prepare someone's life story, an as-told-to, a literally a sort of let's start at the beginning and right through to where we are now, and I would place those with magazines like *Jazz Journal* or *Jazz Monthly* without question. It might run to five thousand words and no one would be bothered, because that's something that hadn't been done and it was something that people wanted to do. I can't do that now. There just isn't — well we've lost something, certainly in the media I work for, we've lost something in the sense of the history of the music. It's much more about now.

MR: They want to hear more about the now players, the up and comers?

PV: The now players, the players with ahem record company linkages if you'll understand me. The guys who are pushing the envelope. I'm interested in those people for sure, but I actually think that Joe Wilder's got the important story. All I can tell you is I've just interviewed Joe Wilder up to a point, not very far into his career, and he's given me a lot of fascinating stuff. There won't be an English magazine that will want to take a piece on Joe Wilder, which is a shame, isn't it?

MR: Just from a — I can't think of the word here — logistical sense, when you do that are you sitting and writing? Are you just taking notes?

PV: No.

MR: You have a little tape recorder? Is that how you do it?

PV: Yeah.

MR: Okay. Do you have a favorite line to get people started? Because if you do maybe I'll borrow it.

PV: Um, I think really I just sort of say look, I really want to talk about your start in things, can we go right back. "Well you mean right back?" Yeah let's go back as far as you want to go. Let's just talk about your family life and how things started. Give me a little picture of your family circumstances. Something like that. And most people will paint you a little picture of where they lived, maybe the kind of environment their parents were part of, you know, and then usually you'll sort of get into well where did music sort of come into the picture. Like Joe was telling me today you see, his father was, I didn't know this, a professional bass violin player. He started on the cornet, went to the sousaphone. So he was telling me all about that and the bands that his father played, and that sort of opened up how he came to be involved in music. And you know it leads on from there.

MR: When you are at a festival like this and I was observing you just tonight taking notes.

PV: Yeah.

MR: What kind of notes do you take on live music that you're listening to so that later you can make a piece out of it?

PV: I'm a bit of a compulsive note taker. It's a funny process. I write, you know, like almost a little narrative of the set. And hopefully, you just kind of find a word or a phrase that just kind of pops out. And you pin that down on paper. And that can be a kicking off point for something that you actually say. I'm not going to write a piece that says at the beginning of the set he played "Indiana" and then he played — whatever. You're trying to paint a little picture. I mean I've got to do two articles about this, one for a magazine called *Jazzwise*, I've got 300 words to describe a great deal of music. Right? I've doing another piece which will be like a color piece, as we would call it, and it's 750 words. So it's a powerful process of compression, isn't it? What you do, you're just trying to find that little phrase which leaves some idea, a picture of what we're about, what actually occurred. But you can't, there's no way you can describe it piece by piece.

MR: Do you have any favorite adjectives?

PV: Impactive. I find impactive I'm using rather too often recently.

MR: Impactive?

PV: Yes.

MR: Oh.

PV: Um. We all have our own cliches you know. My other one is "underpin." If you read my stuff, the word "underpin" appears too often.

MR: I don't know, sometimes you read things and they make statements that mean everything and nothing. Like the "quintessential player." And what is that exactly?

PV: Yeah, well people say well what happens if someone has performed badly? It's very difficult. I'm always interested in what the artistic pretensions are, or what the artistic intentions are. If an artist appears to be claiming a degree of significance and then fails to perform up to that degree of significance I will say so. But if an artist who I respect and who has made no such claims simply doesn't perform very well I will find a way, as it were, of not saying that. I will try to find some way of saying something like the drummer's contributions were not noteworthy. Or the drummer's contributions neither added much nor detracted from the performance. You are damning with faint praise if you like. I don't think it's my role to say this man is an idiot. But I can leave something semi-said and someone will read between the lines.

MR: Is there someone you hear frequently that in their own estimation of their playing is very unpretentious that you feel constantly rises to the occasion?

PV: Well I think Ruby [Braff] is a good example of that, isn't he? I think essentially that is what I've found so inspiring about him. But I've known Ruby a great many years now. And he never fails to find something special to say, yet I don't think he's trying to stand

up and say hang on, I'm of considerable artistic significance therefore please, you know, treat me in that sort of way. I'll give you an example. I wrote a piece about him when he was appearing at Pizza Express in London, which is still a famous jazz club. And it's a club where people come in to eat, and they make a lot of noise. They clatter and chatter and it's the sort of place in the center of London where people come in to eat who have no interest really in whether it's Ruby Braff or Vera Lynn. It's just an incidental. And I don't like that. And I wrote a long piece, you know which ended up with something like what a shame it was that the audience didn't pay sufficient attention to music of this quality. And Ruby telephoned me. He said what were you saying all that in the article? I said well it's what I believe. I said it's a damn shame that they should have talked and clattered about. He said look hang on, I'm a saloon player. This is like a saloon. These guys are in a saloon. I'm a saloon player. I expect that kind of noise and chatter. I thought all right.

MR: You anticipated a question I had.

PV: Absolutely.

MR: Like how many times have you gotten feedback?

PV: Yup. That's right you see.

MR: Do you get positive feedback too?

PV: Yes. It is pleasing if a musician makes the point. Alan Ganley for instance, who I've known Gan many years, unfailingly courteous. And I mean I quite often review his big band. He has a rather fine big band. He would always telephone. And that's very nice. It's courteous and there's a sense of it being something we're both in together. I mean I feel I'm part of it in the sense that I'm trying to support it if you follow me. Other musicians have dropped me a line or rung me up and said look, you've got it right man, which is a pleasing reaction. Very occasionally someone will say hmmm, not too sure about your comments there. And you realize that you've just stepped a little bit towards a nerve. And I mean there's a couple of musicians, I won't name names, in Britain, whose wives are singers. Well they are fine players. They also have wives who are singers. Are you following my drift?

MR: Absolutely.

PV: But the problem is to have him, you must have her. And there's one I know very, very well who, he's really quite a good friend. And if I don't praise his wife, wow. And I don't want to praise her because frankly she's not of the same caliber as her husband. So that can be a little bit sticky.

MR: Yeah. I understand that you also have a role sometimes that you don't really enjoy and that's writing obituaries for people that are still with us?

PV: Yeah. Well I'm an obituary writer for "The Guardian" which is a national newspaper. And as often the case, one is writing obituaries ahead of time. It's a peculiar feeling. I also find it creatively quite hard to do because somehow, you know if I ring the paper, I mean do you remember Kenny Baker, the British trumpet player?

MR: Um hum.

PV: Well I got the first news of his death and I phoned the paper and they said fine. It was like this was four o'clock in the afternoon. And they said can you have 800 words by six o'clock, which concentrates the mind, doesn't it? And somehow the adrenaline gets that going. It really works. I'm a deadline person. If someone said let's have it done by six o'clock you think get cracking. I'll just leave that let's go. And somehow the adrenaline for that is different to that that's required for this obituary that one is doing ahead of time. Do you understand me?

MR: But you've got to have a great deal of knowledge already to sort of do that. You can't start saying where's the book, you know, and start from scratch.

PV: The guys I write about, who the paper would expect me to be able to write about, I've usually got a file on them. I've got extensive files on key individuals. Because I mean I'm interested. I'm just a magpie for information. So I've got a whole house full of stuff. Talk to my wife and she'll tell you that the piles are getting bigger.

MR: You know I think I'm probably spoiled in the job that I've been able to do in that I don't have to work nearly as hard gathering interviews as I think some people do, and probably yourself. What lengths have you gone to, can you think of a couple of instances where you've really gone to super human efforts?

PV: Well I've certainly gone over to the continent with a very specific desire to locate certain people. I mean it's not super human but I've had three trips to Los Angeles specifically to get the older black guys because that's a particular area of interest. Following on from this moment with Darensbourg, I spent a lot of time in Los Angeles with Joe when we were starting to get all the material for this together, and that exposed me to a whole scene over there, you know that's been to some extent documented by *Central Avenue Sounds* and Stephen A. — what's his name — Isoardi.

MR: Sounds right.

PV: Anyway, the guy who has managed that program. But there are still guys I got to that they never did and I've actually still got those interviews. I mean in that sense yes, you are getting into some trouble. You're getting into the black area of Los Angeles, you know you're not too sure how easy that's going to be, and I suppose that would come up too. It's not super human, but at least an out of the ordinary effort. And I say going over to France, going over to Holland where I've certainly been to see key American musicians who are living there, that sort of thing.

MR: Who is the fellow you had to take into the grocery store?

PV: Oh that was Joe Darensbourg.

MR: What was the reason for that?

PV: Well Joe was quite a colorful character, and if you read this book you'll say the ways in which he was colorful. Joe was a Creole from Louisiana who was first married to a Creole woman, well basically because he put her in the family way, secondly he was married to a black lady, and thirdly he was married to a white woman. So as he always said to me, he covered all bases as you would put it. And the third Mrs. Darensbourg, who is a very nice lady, but I think she was from North Carolina, quite straight laced. And to be honest, she was the one that saw to the later years of Joe and to his considerable success and prosperity. She managed his life in a way that put him on the straight and narrow. But she was a bit straight laced. And when we got talking about some of his more nefarious activities, particularly his various sexual liaisons and things like that, I think I told you the other evening, in the background of the tapes you can hear her saying, "He doesn't want to know about that, Joe." Well he did want to know about it. So we found ways to kind of continue to tape recording in unusual places, including the car when he was driving me around, and this particular occasion when we went round the supermarket while he was collecting the groceries. So I was interviewing him while he was sort of collecting the cereal and the bits and pieces. And that way we got 'round his wife kind of putting an editorial hand on things.

MR: What does his wife think of the book?

PV: She was ecstatic.

MR: Oh good.

PV: Yeah. Well it did justice to her Joe, because it came out just after he died unfortunately. He never saw the final thing. But it did justice in her views to Joe. She was proud as proud could be of her husband and a terrific booster of her husband, therefore this was the right and proper thing that should be done, and she never made any comments about it editorially. Well I'll tell you what was most interesting about that, Joe is a Creole. He had two lots of brothers and sisters because his father married twice. And much of what I speak about in the early part of the book is about a Creole guy who, as he put it, covers both ways. That is to say he was a member of both the white and the black locals in Los Angeles, which is quite interesting, isn't it? And he would work in Mexican bands, in white bands, in Creole bands, in black bands. And the real hassle we got was from the second lot of siblings, the half-brothers and half-sisters, all of whom were passing for white. And we had named their names in the original text. And I was threatened with a lawsuit by them unless I removed their names, because they were in a stage of their lives where they wanted no truck with someone who had appeared to be willing to live the

black lifestyle as Joe was. Because Joe didn't give a damn about all that. So I was threatened. I don't know how strongly or realistically, but I was threatened with some kind of legal action unless they were removed. Well I thought it wrong. You can't deny that they existed. You can't deny a whole part of Joe's family. But we didn't put names. You'll find there's a few names missing, a family who did not wish to be named.

MR: That Creole question is really quite complex.

PV: Yeah. For sure. From Louisiana through to California, you know. There's a whole Creole scene still in California.

MR: How they define themselves or how other people define them.

PV: Well you know Johnny St. Cyr was a Creole and he was as black as the ace of spades wasn't he? Joe would look Hispanic to you if he were here today. He was a Creole. A Creole, officially, as I understand it, is a mixture of French, Spanish and black. And he was never unhappy about that. That was a perfectly fair description for him. His brothers and sisters did not wish that to be — the description that they wanted to hear or to see in print.

MR: Is there anything in England that's analogous to that?

PV: Well we of course, we are now more and more of a mixture in England, aren't we? We have a tremendous number of Afro-Caribbeans in Britain and of course black African, black American, black British of West African descent, Nigerians and the like, a lot of Asians, so there is a some degree of intermixing. And you are still aware of the fact that gradations of color are considered important. Lighter is better than darker, which I understand was the case here also in the early days. King Oliver wouldn't employ guys who were really dark.

MR: He wouldn't?

PV: Oh no. He was very dark, but he didn't want anyone else in the band that was very dark because the perception was that that was somehow socially less good. A light colored band looked more acceptable.

MR: More likely to get work perhaps.

PV: Uh huh.

MR: It's a funny world you know. I remember the first time I saw a black person on television speaking with a very strong English accent, it just seemed very strange.

PV: Well we've all got these sort of perceptions, haven't we?

MR: Yes we do. I was going to run a few names by you and just maybe make a comment on them. Actually King Oliver was going to be a name.

PV: Again you see at the time I came up or got interested, there was a terrific focus, I mean people like Humphrey Lyttelton were enamored of the work particularly of the King Oliver Creole Jazz Band. And then of course the Louis Armstrong Hot Five. Sandy

Brown and Al Fairweather were, you know, bowled over by that group of original innovators. Then a slightly later group became very involved with Bunk Johnson and George Lewis. So where I stood was on the King Oliver, Louis Armstrong, Kid Ory line. And I think I can remember buying my first 78 of the King Oliver Band, you know, "Canal Street Blues," I mean we knew this was the real thing. And of course the young Louis was in there so that was powerful. To give you a little insight, not to ask, but I remember interviewing Al Fairweather who was Sandy Brown's trumpet player, a wonderful trumpet player, very Louis Armstrong based. And he was describing the sort of formative experience that he and Sandy Brown went through. They were both at the same school. It's a bit parallel to my story but they were much more talented. They would walk along Edinburgh, the High Street in Edinburgh, singing the respective clarinet and trumpet parts of each of the Hot Five tracks in a row. And they could do that. The music was sort of so powerful they'd absorbed it. See we all used to listen to records in a very intense sort of way. My friend was the trumpet player I mentioned to you. If I got a new record I'd ring him up you see, I'd phone him up. I'd play the record to him over the phone. I'm holding the phone over the old fashioned type phonograph as you would call it, and he'd say, "Put it on again." And I'd play it again. And if he got a new record he'd do the same for me. It's daft, isn't it. That was the enthusiasm.

MR: You have to be that way if you're going to do something close to the music.

PV: And the truth is we knew those early recordings far better than the ones we've got now. Because we played them over and over.

MR: How about Jack Teagarden?

PV: Well that's the reason I stopped playing the trombone. I heard Jack Teagarden. I'd got over my Kid Ory phase. I could do a bit of that. And then I heard this man Teagarden and what he was doing with the trombone and I think I realized that I'd met my match. The moment had passed you know. Fabulous. Fabulous player. Saw him once. Saw him in '57. He came over with a super band led by Earl Hines with Max Kaminsky and Cozy Cole on drums, and Jack Lesberg was playing the bass. That was in '57. And we saw Teagarden play that amazing thing where he takes the bell of the instrument off and he puts the water glass over the end of the slide and just plays the slide. You know? Takes the bell of the instrument away, puts the water glass over the bit of piping that would have been connected to the bell and just plays the slide.

MR: Oh my.

PV: It's a fabulous sound. I saw him do that. I can always remember that.

MR: Great. What about Cannonball Adderley?

PV: Spoken to him once, saw the band in its heyday, they were in Britain about 60, 61, you know with Nat. And I interviewed Louis Hayes, who was Cannonball's drummer. And

my great pal came with me to photograph him and we published the story. Louis Hayes was a young man then. We published the story and we published a photograph which was Louis Hayes in his pajamas. Fair enough? He hadn't got up.

MR: That's a good angle.

PV: He was in his pajamas. So yes, I was knocked out by Cannonball, no doubt about it.

MR: Uh, John Lennon?

PV: Not very interested.

MR: Okay.

PV: I mean the Beatles, you know, we are of an age when that was the popular music at the time that my wife and I were married in 1961. And of course, yeah, its kind of music, and I'm not knocking it at all, I don't think we were caught up in it at that sense. Because by then, you know, jazz was part of our lives. We were going to see bands, and we were seeing any American visits, because we had, in that late 50s period right through I suppose to maybe the early 70s, we had a remarkable booking agency called the Harold Davison office. And every month we had a major tour. The Lionel Hampton band came in to do nineteen dates. The next month it's the Basie band doing nineteen dates. The next month it's Ellington. The next month it's Ella Fitzgerald. The next month it's Jazz at the Phil. So there was so much going on that my jazz interest was being constantly fed and there was so much interest in pursuing those opportunities of pop music, which is something to go to, to dance to, or to enjoy in a social situation. But I certainly wasn't particularly interested nor am I now to be honest.

MR: Okay. What about Ronnie Scott?

PV: Well we know of course that Ronnie had started a club, and I went to the early club a couple of times in what they call Ronnie Scott's old place, which was a sort of small basement which had been formerly a taxicab driver's place in Soho. What they call a cabman's shelter. It was where cabbies could go and have an off-duty cup of tea. And Ronnie got hold of it and he started the club. And I remember seeing Lucky Thompson there, a small room about half the size of this space we're in, at about two and six pence, which is like, well that'd be fifty cents or something, and I heard Lucky Thompson. That's the only time I heard Lucky Thompson.

MR: Who in your estimation is the greatest, or most influential British jazz product?

PV: It's difficult to say isn't it? Well for different reasons I guess, there's no question Humphrey Lyttelton has made an extraordinary impact. Humph will be 80 this coming year. He's had a band now for 50 years. Every British player of consequence has been in that band. Humph's also been, he's a Renaissance man, he's presented a Monday night best of jazz radio program for 30 years. He's written several excellent books, both an autobiography and of explanation of musical study. He's an excellent trumpet player.

He's composed probably a hundred or more original compositions. And he has probably the highest profile. He's a most interesting character. He's from a very privileged background. He's an old Etonian, I mean Eton is our most prestigious public school, or you'd call it a private school. He comes from aristocratic stock and here was this extraordinary man who moved into a world of playing jazz music, which somehow was at odds with that kind of background. He was an officer of the guards during the war, which was also very prestigious, yet he became what he is still today, you know, an outstanding trumpeter and performer. So I'd give him huge marks. He did a lot to put jazz on the map, if you like, in Britain. Others again were Shearing obviously, Johnny Dankworth would be a very powerful contributor, and Ronnie Scott for sure. And there's other very good individuals, but I'd be hard put to think of someone very much better than Humph. Stan Tracey, a wonderful piano player.

MR: I don't know how to ask this question, but do British people resent the fact that a lot of your best artists seem to come here and stay?

PV: Well originally I think we felt great pride you see. The idea was that if you could make it in the States, by golly that was a tremendous accolade. Because after all America was the home of the music. So when let's say someone like Shearing came here, Ronnie Ball, the bebop piano player, came here, of course Victor Feldman.

MR: Oh right.

PV: One of our great exports. There was a sense, it's a kind of coals to Newcastle thing. Hey, if these guys have been able to make it in the States, which is the home of the music, that's a tremendous plaudit for them. And I think that was the attitude that most of us took. I don't think there's an opinion now. No one would say of Keith Ingham my gosh he sold out by going to the States, he should have stayed home. That's fair enough. Today's environment, why shouldn't he go here. Let him go where he wants to go, let him see what he can do you know.

MR: In a broader sense I'm interested in what Britain thinks of the United States as a whole? How do they look at our last November's mess with the election?

PV: Well I think we think that was laughable. It got a lot of space. But we think that Clinton's escapades were grotesque really. So you know, I don't think the great British public would have too strong an opinion either way. They'd say they're all a bunch of rogues and vagabonds. They don't feel much different about our own politicians to be honest. So I don't think that did America any favors, let's put it that way. But the extent of American influence is very considerable. Obviously films, certainly T.V., and a lot of American lifestyle aspects, you know, the dreaded fast food for instance, plenty of that.

MR: McDonald's on every corner?

PV: For sure. There'll be a thousand outlets by the end of next year I think in Britain. That's a lot, isn't it?

MR: Yeah.

PV: About 999 too many perhaps. No I think there's always, look, there is what is called a special relationship. We are close to each other in many ways. That's not to say that we think alike. George Bernard Shaw said, "Two nations divided by a common language," and there is still something of that. But I think we feel pretty comfortable with the relationship I guess.

MR: If you got an assignment to write about someone who has been written about a lot, could you envision how you would find your own angle to get at this person?

PV: My own attitude or my own tendency is usually to look at the history. In other words I did a piece on the pianist Rene Rosnes not too long ago. Well I wanted to find out what made her tick. I didn't actually want to do another puff about her latest record. What editors want often is just don't talk to her about her record. You know that will please the record company. Well I'd much rather sort of find out what made her the pianist she is in terms of her influences, a little bit of her history and background, and maybe one or two of the, well incidents in her life. And that's what I did. So I tend to want to find out about the jumping off point. What made a person become what they are? What was the kick start? That's where I would tend to go. And also maybe to get a little something about the environment. Because America is such a range of fascinating contrasts. It's (a) a polyglot population and community, and (b) there is such diverse differences, aren't there? Because of the enormity of the country, because of the many strands of cultural change and variation, and it's quite interesting to talk to people about that.

MR: Did you ever get an assignment to write liner notes for a recording that you didn't like?

PV: I'm just trying to think. I don't think so. Well I did do one recently for a Mike Westbrook reissue and I thought the music was pretty — well it left me fairly cold. I think you do as professional a job as you can. I sought to describe it. I sought to highlight what seemed to me to be the aspects that were valuable, and did it as honestly as I could. But of course the liner notes, as the late Stanley Dance put it, is a form of sales promotion, isn't it? It's unusual to start a liner and say this is unbelievably unpleasant music. So you have to find ways. That's rare though.

MR: Speaking of unpleasant, did you ever have an interview that just left you feeling embarrassed or like you really put your foot in it somehow?

PV: I'll have to think about that. I think the things that embarrass me is where I find or where it appears early on that I should have done a hell of a lot more research. I think that is embarrassing. You know when a guys says, "Well don't you know about my recordings?" Ah. That's a tricky moment. And that's perhaps where one's been a little bit

too quick to fix the interview, on a sort of sense of saying well this guy won't be here more than another day, I must do it now. And you can quite often regret that you didn't have that time. And I know I've not been as professional as I should have been.

MR: Has the Internet and all the explosion of information helped you?

PV: Yeah I use it occasionally. I find it's too seductive. It can take up too much time. You know if you're not careful you can kind of wile away a couple of hours and if you're really truthful the value you've had from that time may not have been that great. So it's just, it's a background tool. But that's as far as it goes I think.

MR: Do you have any immediate goals for future writing coming up?

PV: I always want to do some books you see. I mean that's the one book I've done. I've just done a chapter for a rather good book on saxophonists. And I do want to do more of that sort of thing. Because as I was talking the other day, transcribing interviews is the thing that bugs me most. And that remains an issue I have to say.

MR: Yeah. I'm pretty lucky that way.

PV: I know you are. I'm going to come and live in your house. No it's still this idea that one wants to document. Each time I hear of guy that's died I think damn, we didn't get to him. And also I've got a very substantial photo archive and I'm kind of always trying to grab the photos, if only to have the chance to copy them. Because otherwise I know they'll be dished. They'll be thrown away other than in certain very particular situations. Like Dan Morgenstern was telling us about the Mary Lou Williams Archive which runs to something like 27 boxes of everything. That's rare. So often you get to someone and they say oh no, we threw all that away. I still have a feeling that we ought to be stopping that, that stuff shouldn't be thrown away. So I think there's still that sense that I started out with of wanting to document something. Because the kind of people I'm interested in came out of a time — I was just talking with Joe Wilder — you are talking about a guy who wanted to be a classical trumpet player. He went to the Mastbaum School in Philadelphia which prepared classical trumpet players. But he was black. There was no opportunity. So his experiences are formed by that situation aren't they? And I think it's important to document those. Because if you spool forward and you look at Wynton, Wynton was playing the "Hummel Concerto" with the New Orleans Symphony when he was sixteen, wasn't he? No one said to Wynton you can't be a classical player because you're black. And I'm interested still to pursue that documenting of that period, the veteran guys, the best of the lot. But there's a real story there, when America was sort of in a formative stage. You know when you talk to someone like Jay McShann, as I'm sure you've done, you're talking about a guy that was born in Oklahoma when it wasn't a state, was it? It was Indian country. And there's Indian blood in McShann. And just

talking about things like that, it's another time and it needs to be sort of documented and preserved.

MR: Well I'm glad there's guys out there like you doing it.

PV: Well thank you.

MR: I appreciate it.

PV: We'll try.

MR: It's been great having this chance to talk to you.

PV: A pleasure, thank you for asking me.

MR: Is there anything that you'd like to wrap up with about what you do?

PV: Well the only thing is that it's always been a parallel life. I've had serious jobs in industry. I mean I was the director of a public company. That was, if you like, how I made my living and paid the bills and raised my family. But there was always this parallel life. And while I was working for the *Melody Maker*, which I did for about fifteen years, I was always a freelance. I was what is called a stringer. And people found it quite odd that I would go to Ronnie Scott's to hear Stan Getz — I was managing a factory at that time. And I'd be coming in early to my plant, at eight o'clock in the morning, I'd got home at two o'clock, I'd written 350 words immediately on getting home, and by eight o'clock I was in my office and I was phoning it on to the stone, it was direct to the text taker to go straight down onto the stone. See it printed on a Tuesday. Ronnie Scott's opens on a Monday. And you know, my boss would sometimes wander in the room when I was doing this. And I'd say I'm sorry I'm doing something important, do you mind getting out? But I think people think it quite interesting, this mad person wishing to pursue these parallel lines. Well for the last thirteen, fourteen years, I haven't had that problem, I'm a full time freelance now.

MR: Good.

PV: But it made for some funny moments.

MR: All right. Well I hope we cross paths again sometime.

PV: Well I hope so too, it's been great. And I'm delighted at what you're doing, you know. Keep it up, sir.

MR: I will.

PV: Okay.

MR: I've got the world's greatest gig.

PV: Yes. I think you have actually. Don't tell too many people.

MR: I won't.

PV: Does that have any value or meaning at all?

MR: I think it did.

PV: Was that remotely interesting? Can't have been.

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